

Europe



Despite regional variations, European herbal practices largely arose from the common root of the classical tradition. Today, herbalism is increasingly popular in Europe, and in some countries it is widely practiced by orthodox medical practitioners as well as by qualified herbalists.

Each of the world's major herbal traditions developed its own framework for making sense of illness. In Europe, the principal model for understanding and explaining illness was the "theory of the four humors," which persisted well into the 17th century. It was laid down by Galen (131–201 CE), physician to the Roman emperor Marcus Aurelius. Galen was born in Pergamum, and part of his medical practice involved caring for the gladiators of the city, which gave him the opportunity to learn about anatomy and the remedies best suited to healing wounds. He wrote literally hundreds of books and had a crucial influence on European medicine for over 1,500 years. To this day, plant medicines are sometimes called Galenicals to distinguish them from synthesized drugs.

The Theory of the Four Humors

Galen developed his ideas from the texts of Hippocrates (460–c. 377 BCE) and Aristotle (384–322 BCE), who in turn had been influenced by Egyptian and Indian ideas. Hippocrates, expanding on the early belief that the world was made up of the elements fire, air, earth, and water, classified herbs as having hot, dry, cold, and moist properties. Aristotle developed and endorsed the theory of the four humors. According to the theory, four principal fluids—or humors—exist within the body: blood, choler (yellow bile), melancholy (black bile), and phlegm. The "ideal" person bore all four in equal proportion. However, in most people, one or more humors predominate, giving rise to particular temperaments or characters. For instance, excess choler produced a choleric-type person, who was likely to be short-tempered, sallow, ambitious, and vengeful. Galen also believed that *pneuma* (spirit) was taken in with each breath, and processed in the body to form the "vital spirit." Vitality and health depended upon the proper balance between the four humors and the four elements and the correct mix with the inspired *pneuma*.

Influence of Classical Herbalists

Two other classical writers strongly influenced the European herbal tradition. Dioscorides (40–90 CE), a Greek-born Roman army surgeon, wrote the classical world's most comprehensive book on herbal medicines, *De Materia Medica*, based on observations of nearly 600 plants. Pliny the Elder (23–79 CE) drew together writings from over 400 authors in his *Natural History*, recording, among other things, herbal lore of the time. Much traditional European knowledge of medicinal herbs comes from Dioscorides and Pliny. One of the most interesting herbs mentioned by both is

Valerian tincture

St. John's wort (*Hypericum perforatum*, p. 106) is an astringent and antiviral herb, and is widely used in Europe as a remedy for depression.

St. John's wort infused oil

Dried St. John's wort

Valerian (*Valeriana officinalis*, p. 148) is a good herb for calming nervous tension.

Goldenrod (*Solidago virgaurea*, p. 271) is an astringent herb taken for sore throats, congestion, and problems of the urinary tract.

Calendula (*Calendula officinalis*, p. 73) is an age-old remedy for soothing inflamed skin.

Fresh and dried calendula petals